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Title: Memorial to man behind Hortus withers away — The Hindu (Kochi)

Memorial to man behind Hortus withers away — The Hindu (Kochi)

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Article summary (research excerpt)

Published 19 February 2013 (updated 12 November 2016). Reports on the deteriorating memorial to Itty Achuthan Vaidyar, the Ezhava physician credited with supplying local plant and medicinal knowledge for Hendrik van Rhee's Hortus Malabaricus.

Fifty-two-year-old Umayamma, from a village near Cherthala, recalls family stories about her ancestor, a local medicine man associated with the Dutch catalogue of Malabar flora. Itty Achuthan Vaidyar of Kadakkarappally was one of the leaders of a team of botanical experts assembled by van Rhee in the 1670s.

*“He learnt about medicinal plants from his ancestors and achieved great prominence at a very young age.
— Umayamma”*

A small wooden structure called the ‘kuriala,’ said to have existed since the time of the Vaidyar, stands as a memorial. Umayamma and family light a lamp there every evening. Researchers studying Hortus Malabaricus or Dutch Malabar history visit the grove and kuriala, including visitors from the Netherlands.

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